

POSC 3710: European Politics

9/14/2026: CHRISTIAN DEMOCRACY AND SOCIAL DEMOCRACY

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Sweden voted yesterday

Party	2022	13 Sept 2026
Social Democrats	30.3%	28%
Sweden Democrats	20.5%	18%
Moderates	19.1%	20%
Left Party	6.8%	8%
Centre Party	6.7%	7%
Christian Democrats	5.3%	6%
Greens	5.1%	6%
Liberals	4.6%	5%

WHAT TO WATCH

- The Social Democrats, led by former prime minister Magdalena Andersson, led the polls all year; the last Novus poll had them at 25.8% and the two blocs within three points
- The centre-right Moderates under Prime Minister Ulf Kristersson have governed since 2022 with the votes of the far-right Sweden Democrats (the Tidö Agreement)
- A party needs 4% to enter the Riksdag
- The Swedish Social Democrats are Berman's model case

Where the two families govern, September 2026

CHRISTIAN DEMOCRATS

Lead in Germany and Austria, in office in three more countries

- Germany: the CDU/CSU leads under Chancellor Friedrich Merz, in coalition with the Social Democrats (SPD)
- Austria: the People's Party (ÖVP) leads under Chancellor Christian Stocker, with the Social Democrats (SPÖ)
- Netherlands: the CDA sits in Prime Minister Rob Jetten's (D66) new cabinet. Belgium: two Christian democratic parties sit in Prime Minister Bart De Wever's coalition. Ireland: Fine Gael shares power
- Italy: the DC, dominant to 1992, dissolved in 1994 after corruption scandals. Its nearest heir, Forza Italia, is a junior partner in Prime Minister Giorgia Meloni's government

SOCIAL DEMOCRATS

Lead in Madrid, Copenhagen, London and Oslo

- Spain: the Socialists (PSOE) lead under Prime Minister Pedro Sánchez (w/Sumar + support from other left + regional parties)
- Denmark: the Social Democrats lead under Prime Minister Mette Frederiksen, re-formed in June after a difficult March election
- United Kingdom: Labour, under Prime Minister Andy Burnham since July, after Keir Starmer resigned. Norway: Labour, re-elected in 2025 under Prime Minister Jonas Gahr Støre
- Junior partners in Germany, Austria and Belgium. Sweden: ???

European Parliament, July 2024: the group the Christian democrats belong to (EPP, 188 seats) and the social democratic group (S&D, 136) are still the two largest of 720. But, they are no longer a majority.

Where We Left Off

- Wednesday: nations are made or imagined, and modern (Gellner; Anderson)
- 8/24: Marx and Hayek on how a society should be run
- 8/31 and 9/2: democracy collapsed between the wars and was rebuilt after 1945
- Today: two new party families emerge and dominate European politics for generations
- Both were middle paths: against revolution and a fully planned economy, and against the unregulated market

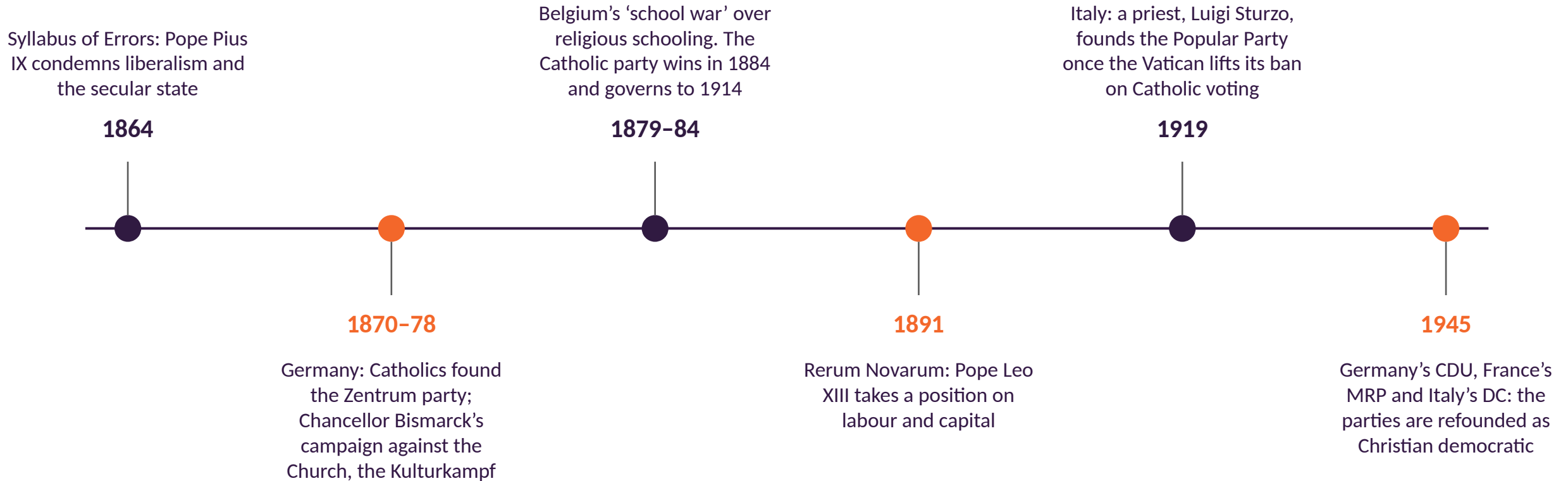
Opening Discussion

- What should government's role in the economy be? Where would you draw the line?
 - Where do you think most Europeans draw it?
- Would you join a political party organized around a religion? What would you expect it to stand for, and who would stay away?
- Why did (most) socialists trade bullets for ballots at the turn of the 20th century?
 - Does this logic still work in 2026?

Why Christian Democracy?

- Christian democrats sat in every Italian government from 1945 to 1994
- They led West Germany for 36 of its first 49 years
- The founders of European integration all came from this family: West Germany's Konrad Adenauer, Italy's Alcide De Gasperi, France's Robert Schuman
- For decades observers treated it as conservatism under another name
 - Deserves to be treated as a distinct movement, with its own origins, ideology and voters

Where the Christian democratic parties came from, 1864–1945



The Church didn't want a party

- Liberal governments attacked the Church's privileges
 - Push for secular education
- The Church answered with lay mass organizations, meant to stay under its control
- Political entrepreneurs saw an opportunity to organize parties around religion
 - Victory gave the lay activists a base of their own, independent of the church
- From the reading: "the politicization of religion contributed to the secularization of politics"

Held Together by Religion

- Religion alone united Catholic workers, farmers, shopkeepers and aristocrats
 - These parties were cross-class from the start
 - Sometimes called “catch-all parties”
- Class conflict moved inside the party: unions, farmers and employers each had their own factions
- Keeping them together took permanent negotiation. Opponents call it opportunism
 - Kalyvas and van Kersbergen: this is the movement's defining skill, the politics of mediation

What Makes Christian Democracy Distinctive

RELIGIOUS INSPIRATION

Christian *and* secular at once

- Religion redefined as a set of morals: 'Christian values', human dignity
- The parties kept the label but split from the church
- A Christian democrat can be agnostic, atheist, Muslim, Jewish, or Hindu (etc)

MEDIATION

Compromise as ideology

- Integration, accommodation, pluralism, class compromise
- Deals between capital and labour, social harmony
- Coalition government comes naturally

SUBSIDIARITY AND PERSONALISM

People live in communities

- Family, parish, workplace and town come before the state
- The state steps in where smaller communities cannot cope
- The nation is one community among many. So is Europe

Kalyvas and van Kersbergen on religion and the parties

“Confessional parties redefined religion into a nebulous humanitarian and moral concept that allowed them to be simultaneously Christian and secular.” p. 188

“It is now perfectly possible to be simultaneously a Christian democrat and an agnostic, atheist, Muslim, or Hindu — and this is not even perceived as a contradiction.” p. 188

“What is a trade-off in social democratic politics may involve a payoff for Christian democracy.” p. 189

Interpreting that final quote: social democracy is about class, Christian democracy was religion/morals, and religion cuts across class. Class harmony can harm Social Democratic parties if people vote on non-class lines; but this can help Christian Democratic parties

Social Capitalism

- Spending at social democratic levels, with different goals
- Passive: income replacement when you lose work, rather than jobs or training
- Built around the family and the male breadwinner.
 - Women's employment *was* discouraged (this has changed)
- Run through insurance funds and the social partners
 - State as a last resort/backstop
- Not looking to change social hierarchies (unlike SD or other left movements).

Two ways to build a welfare state

CHRISTIAN DEMOCRATIC

Security for families, through work

- Who is covered: workers, through employment-based insurance
- Paid for by: payroll contributions from employers and workers
- Administered by: unions and employers
- Aim: a stable family income and social peace
- Women: the breadwinner model kept many at home

SOCIAL DEMOCRATIC

Equality for citizens, through the state

- Who is covered: everyone, as a citizen
- Paid for by: general taxation
- Administered by: the state
- Aim: equality and full employment
- Women: public services made two-earner households normal

We will come back to this when we read Esping-Andersen in the welfare state week

Why They Won (After 1945)

- Fascism destroyed the old right
 - prewar liberalism was discredited
- Anti-communism gave Catholics, conservatives and many workers one party to vote for
- The organization had survived the war: parishes, Catholic unions, farmers' leagues, youth groups
- Women got the vote,
 - Women voted Christian democratic more often than men did (men often in SD affiliated unions)
- 1945-57: Austria's People's Party 49.8%, Italy's DC 48.5%, West Germany's CDU/CSU 50.2%

Europe Was a Christian Democratic Project

- Adenauer, Schuman and De Gasperi (West Germany, France, Italy) built the Coal and Steel Community
- All six founding states had strong Christian democratic parties
- It fit the ideology: mediation, pragmatism, the nation as one community among many
- London's view of the European Community
 - “a Catholic conspiracy, orchestrated from the Vatican”

What They Stand For Today

- Economics: regulated capitalism and a conservative welfare state
- Social policy: families and religious institutions first; moderated on gender equality and LGBT+ rights
- Immigration: mixed.
 - Help the truly needy, particularly refugees and asylum claimants
 - Post 2015 (migrant crisis) move rightwards
- Very pro-Europe, pro-NATO
- Moderately socially conservative, economically pragmatic
 - Rivals with Social Democrats, but also have fruitfully worked and governed together

Social Democracy's Problem

- Marxism after Marx: economics drives history, and capitalism collapses on its own
 - Berman calls it an “obstetric” view: wait, and play midwife
- By 1900 capitalism was flourishing and the socialist parties were large
 - But no theory of how to take power
- Eduard Bernstein, a leading German socialist, wrote that the theory was wrong (1899).
 - Ballots not Bullets

Orthodoxy and revisionism, 1899

ORTHODOX MARXISM

Historical materialism and class struggle

- History is moved by economic development, and by nothing else
- Capitalism's contradictions will bring it down
- The proletariat, growing and immiserated, drive change
- Reform delays the inevitable; allies dilute the class

REVISIONISM: BERNSTEIN

The primacy of politics and cross-class cooperation

- Capitalism is adapting; socialism depends "not on the decrease but on the increase of... wealth"
- Socialism will come through human action, or it will not come
- Workers share interests with most of society; the middle classes and peasantry are allies
- "... the ultimate aim of socialism is nothing, but the movement is everything"

The Primacy of Politics

- Berman: social democracy is “a full-fledged alternative to both Marxism and liberalism”
- Its core: the primacy of politics (politics must control economic forces) and communitarianism
- Against Marxism: no waiting for history.
- Against liberalism: markets left alone tear communities apart

Social democracy from theory to government, 1889–1959

Sweden's Social Democratic party is founded; Germany's SPD is already the model for Europe's socialists

1889

1899

Bernstein's book: reform capitalism now, and stop waiting for its collapse

First social democratic governments: Austria (1919), Sweden (1920), Britain's first Labour government (1924)

1919–24

1932

Sweden: Per Albin Hansson becomes prime minister in the Depression and allies with the farmers' party

Britain: Clement Attlee's Labour wins a majority and builds the National Health Service (1948)

1945

1959

West Germany: the SPD's Godesberg programme drops Marxism and declares itself a people's party

Berman's model case is Sweden: a party that campaigned in 1932 on shaping the economy, allied with the farmers, and called itself the party of the whole people: Per Albin Hansson's 'people's home'.

The Social Democrats governed Sweden from 1932 to 1976.

After the War, Everyone Played Nice

- After 1945 the whole spectrum rejected communism and prewar laissez-faire liberalism
- West Germany's Christian Democrats: "the period of uncurtailed rule by private capitalism is over"
- Karl Schiller, later West Germany's economics minister: without the welfare state "the free market system might well have collapsed"
- Berman: what spread after the war was social democracy, whoever implemented it
 - What do we think of this claim?

Learning to Win

- The (German) SPD's postwar leader Kurt Schumacher went back to orthodoxy: nationalization and class struggle.
 - Support collapsed
- 1959, Bad Godesberg: the SPD accepted the market economy — “as much competition as possible, as much planning as necessary”
- Berman: the shift was “at least as much pragmatic as it was principled”
- Sweden never needed the correction: it kept both the ideology and the majority
 - In practice, Sweden's economy has ‘liberalized’ greatly even under Soc Dem government

Compare and Contrast: Differences with the party family

WHAT THEY SHARE

A people's party that puts politics over markets

- Strong labor movements behind the party
- Universal welfare programs: pensions, health, unemployment insurance
- State provision of health, education and utilities
- The state can and should manage the economy

WHERE THEY DIFFER

National habits, not doctrine

- How much the state should own: Britain nationalized coal, rail and steel. Sweden did none of this
- Labor and management: Sweden's 1938 peace pact between unions and employers; Britain's strikes
- How much economic planning
- How openly Marxism was renounced: the SPD in 1959; Labour kept its public-ownership clause until 1995

Class Party or People's Party?

- Berman: after 1918 socialists learned that “workers alone could never deliver an electoral majority”
 - The dilemma: each step toward other voters loosens the party's hold on the workers (see also Pzeworski and Sprague *Paper Stones*)
- Christian democracy: religious voters against the rest
 - Religion cut across class, so the trade-off became a payoff
- Social Democrats increasingly appeal to middle class (more on this in future weeks)
- Both families became catch-all parties.
 - Both are now arguably in identity crises

The Two Middle Paths

CHRISTIAN DEMOCRACY

SOCIAL DEMOCRACY

Founding enemy

The liberal state, then communism

Capitalism, and the bourgeoisie

Core unit

The person in a community: family, parish, town

The working class, or now 'the people'

How it won votes

Religion, cutting across class

Class, or now a cross-class people's party

Why a welfare state

Family stability and social peace

Economic security as a right

The market

Kept, but embedded in social obligation

"Great servants... terrible masters" (Berman)

The nation-state

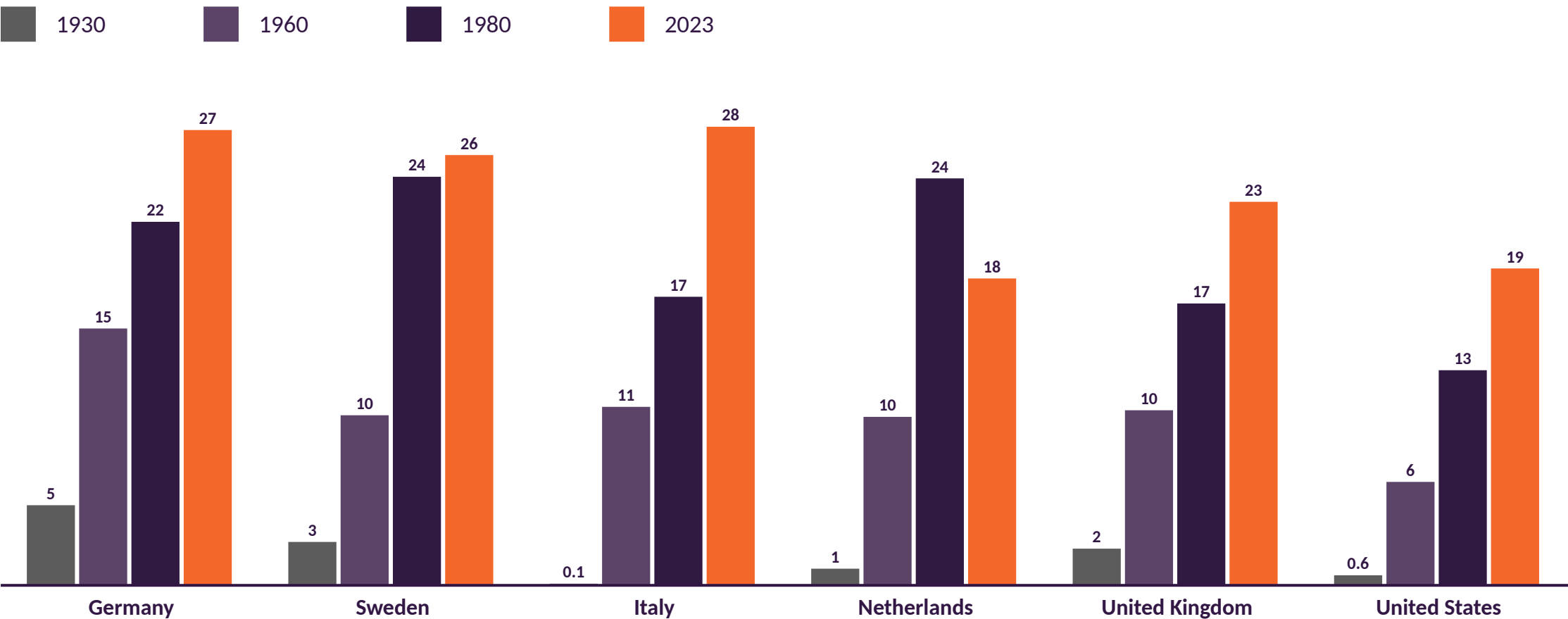
One community among many; Europe came naturally

The tool of reform; most SD parties voted against the Schuman Plan

What They Built Together

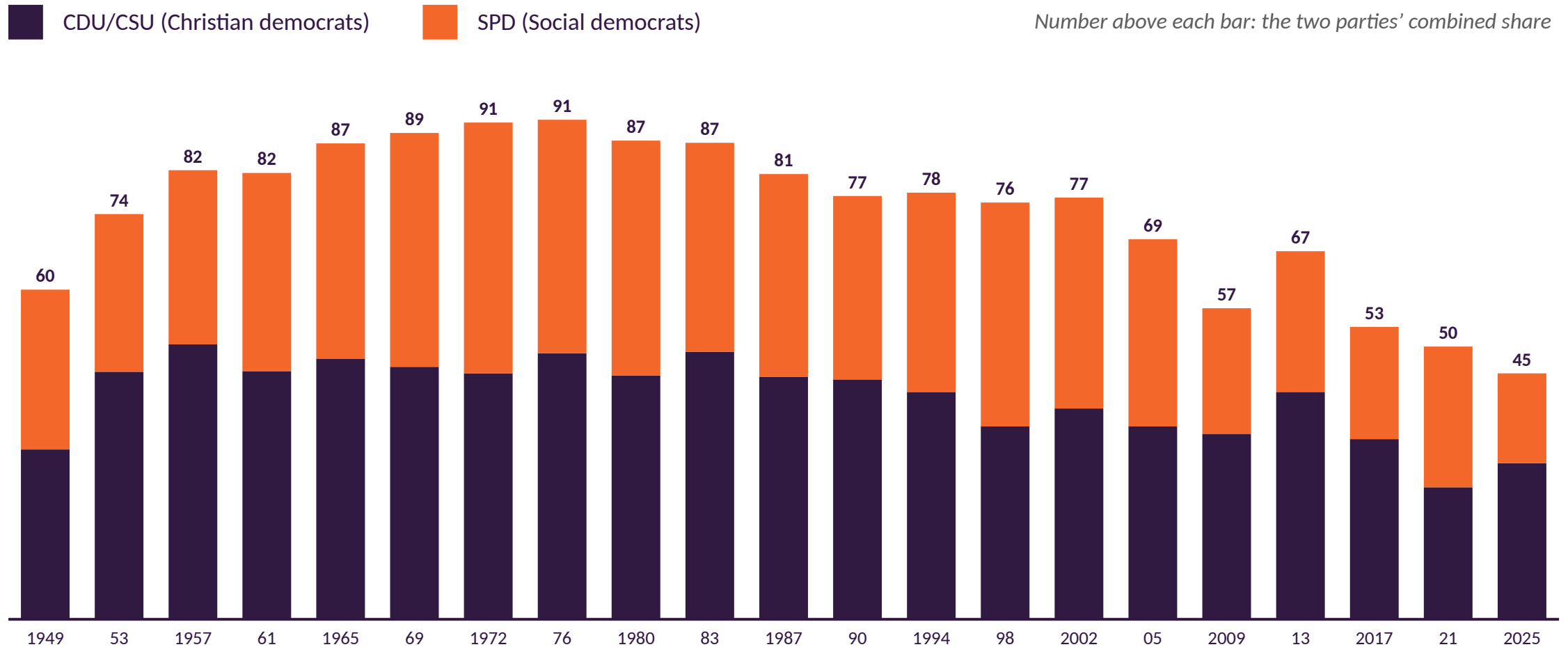
- Berman: non-leftists “appropriate[d] central planks of the social democratic program”
 - Continental welfare states came from coalitions of the two families
- Christian democratic influence: occupational insurance, family benefits, social partners (churches, business groups, voluntary societies) in charge
- Social democratic influence: full employment, universal programs, expansion
- Europe: Christian democrats designed it. The Social Democrats Opposed it, but now are among its main defenders

Public social spending as a share of GDP, 1930–2023



Our World in Data, combining Lindert (2004) with OECD social expenditure data; 1930 values are social transfers only.

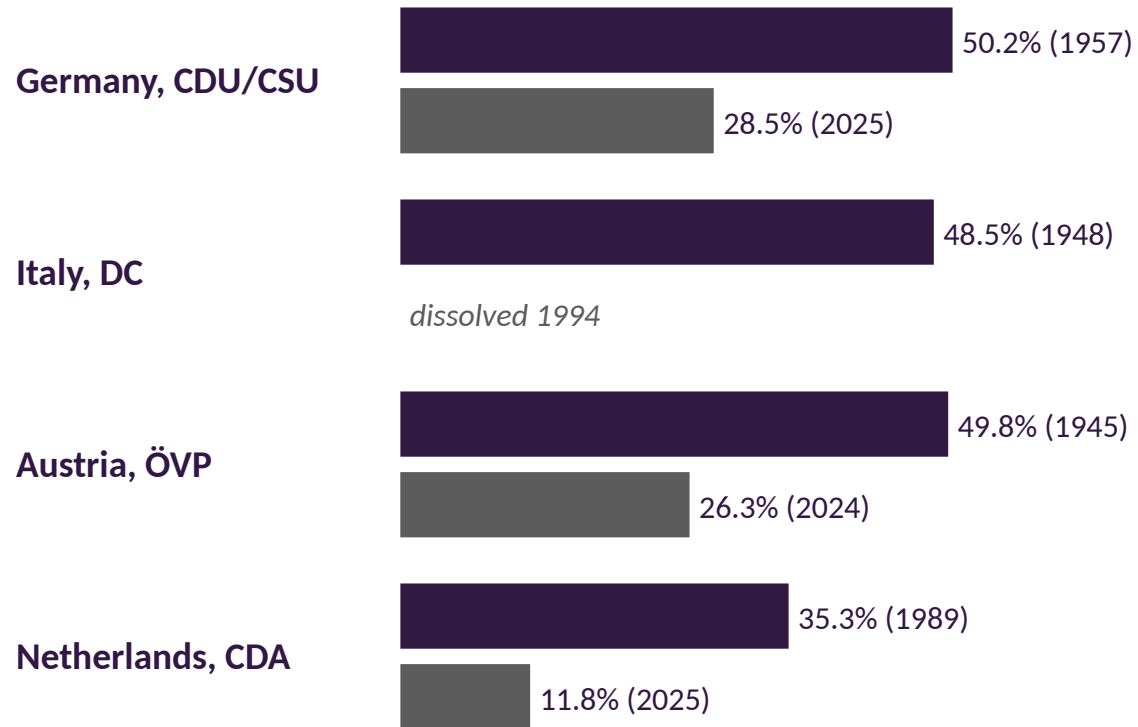
CDU/CSU and SPD, share of the vote in every federal election, 1949–2025



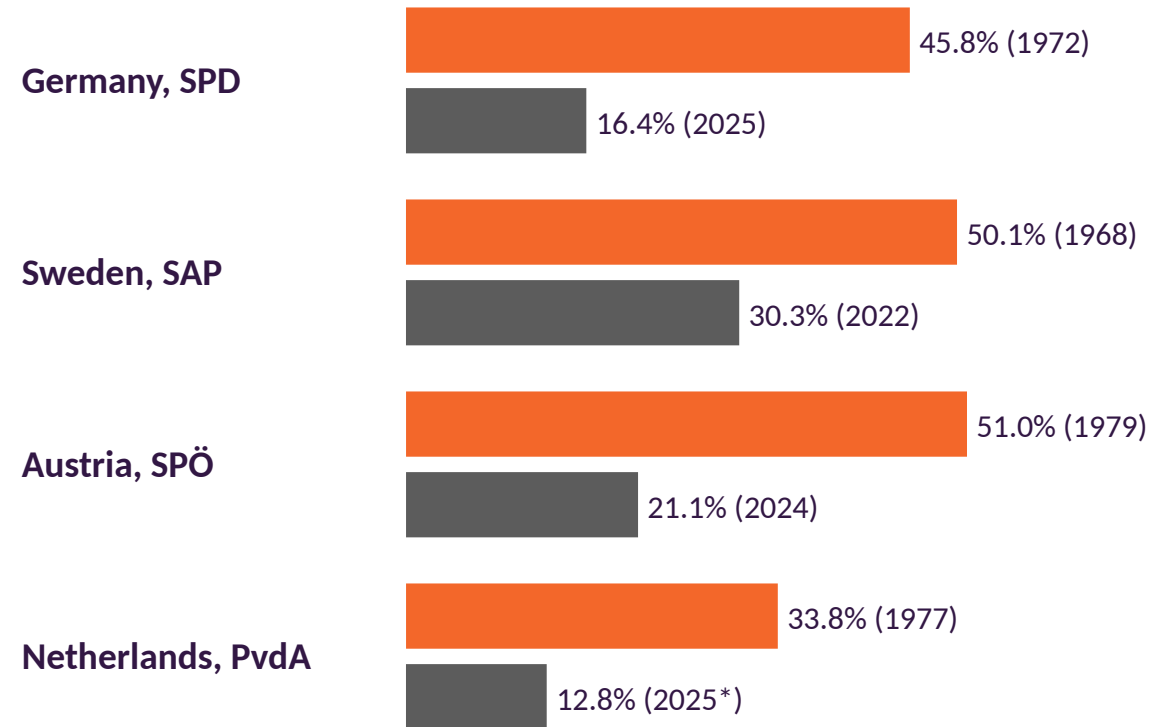
Second votes, Bundeswahlleiterin; 1949–87 West Germany only. In 1972 and 1976 the two families took nine votes in ten between them. The steps down each mark a new party clearing the 5% threshold: Greens, post-communist Left, AfD.

High point and latest results

CHRISTIAN DEMOCRATS



SOCIAL DEMOCRATS



*National lower-house elections, party share of the vote. Colored bar: a high point; grey bar: the latest result. *PvdA ran jointly with the Greens. The Dutch CDA dates from 1980, so its high point is later. Sweden's 2026 result goes on slide 2.*

21st Century Problems

- Deindustrialization: the industrial working class the social democrats were built on has shrunk
- Secularization: the churchgoing base the Christian democrats were built on has shrunk
- Globalization and EU spending rules limit what a national government can promise
- New issues cut across the old ones: immigration, gender, climate, anti-elitism
- Aging populations make the welfare states they built more expensive every year

Discussion

- What allowed social democracy the popular success that revolutionary socialism never had? How did its parties pitch their appeal differently?
- Kalyvas and van Kersbergen say Christian democracy is a distinct ideology; Berman says the same of social democracy. But, many treat these two families as opposite sides of the same coin. What do you think?
- In 1976 the two families took 91% of the West German vote; in 2025, 45%. What changed: the parties, the voters, or the problems?

The Federal Republic of Clemson

- The CD and SD parties in the FRC have real histories. These were the parties that shaped the state!
- Both families won by mediating between groups. Each is now unsure which groups it is for. You need to figure this out!
- Every party: which of these two is your natural coalition partner, and what would it cost you to work with them?
- Manifesto due Wednesday 9/30. Wednesday's class: the European Union